had gradually come to realize that improving local access control was no longer enough. Their ambitions now depended on treating authorization as shared infrastructure. Authorization had become the hard problem because ACME's ambitions had outgrown the assumptions on which its earlier solutions were built.

19.2 The architecture ACME built

By the time the organization recognized authorization as a strategic concern, ACME had already built most of the components of a modern decision infrastructure. ACME's decision infrastructure was not built as a single initiative, but instead emerged through a series of deliberate improvements, each addressing a specific limitation in how access decisions were made or enforced.

Early investments were aimed at reducing duplication and inconsistency. Teams externalized decision logic from application code when local solutions started to diverge (as discussed in chapter 6 on dynamic authorization models). Shared evaluation services were introduced where coordination was needed. As collaboration patterns grew more complex, relationship-based models were deliberately adopted to support controlled sharing (see section 6.1 on ReBAC). Attribute-driven controls were added to address access requirements that static roles could no longer fulfill (see section 6.2 on attribute-based access control).

These changes were incremental but not accidental. Engineers and security leaders increasingly identified recurring decision patterns across systems. Architectural discussions started to explicitly consider how authority should flow through the platform. Over time, authorization ceased being treated as just a feature-level concern and became integral to how new capabilities were designed.

The architecture ACME designed was a direct response to this pressure. Rather than attempting to limit the growth of the decision surface, the company focused on strengthening the infrastructure that supports it. Shared policy services, contextual signals, and governance mechanisms were